1.2 Ordinances of 1785 and 1787

When large groups of people get together but have few rules to follow, things can get wild fast. As settlers moved into territory northwest of the Ohio River, the new United States struggled to maintain law and order beyond its official boundaries.

MAIN IDEA The ordinances of 1785 and 1787 allowed the federal government to better regulate westward expansion and distribute land to new settlers.

GO WEST!

You have read that the Treaty of Paris of 1783 granted the United States most of the territory from the Atlantic Ocean to the Mississippi River. This land extended north to the St. Lawrence River and the Great Lakes and south to the Spanish colony of Florida. Under the Articles of Confederation, the national government controlled all this territory.

Fertile soil attracted white settlers to the land beyond the Appalachian (a-puh-LATCH-uhn) Mountains. Settlers had begun arriving there in 1775, when frontier adventurers such as **Daniel Boone** and some companions created a route through the Appalachian Mountains from Virginia to Kentucky. The new route, called the **Wilderness Road**, enabled large numbers of people to move west. The "western lands," as they were called, included present-day Ohio, Indiana, Illinois, Michigan, Wisconsin, and part of Minnesota.



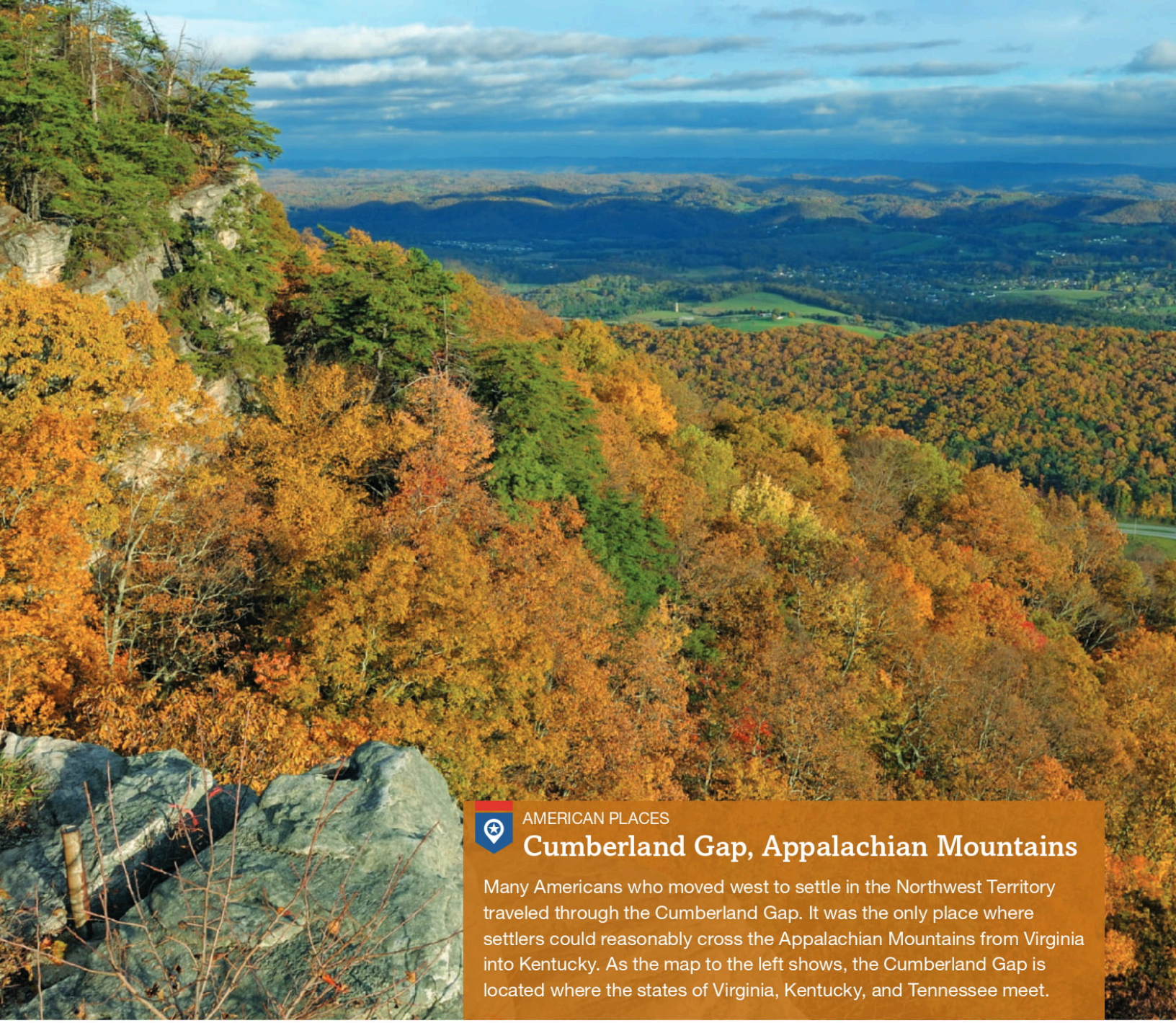
THE NORTHWEST TERRITORY

Territorial expansion and its consequences created a new set of problems for the federal government. Congress recognized the need to provide safety and order within the new settlements, and it also wanted to establish a strong governmental presence in the western lands. Operating under the Articles of Confederation, Congress passed a series of **ordinances**, or laws, for settling the western lands. These ordinances established an orderly system for transferring federally owned land into private holdings, townships, and states. The first ordinance, passed in 1784, divided the territory into a small number of self-governing districts that could later become states.

The second ordinance was the **Ordinance of 1785**. It called for surveying and organizing districts into townships. The townships would be further divided into lots that the government would sell at a minimum of $1 per acre. Each township also had to set aside land for a school.

Finally, the **Northwest Ordinance of 1787** renamed the land the **Northwest Territory**. The ordinance provided for ownership of land by individuals and for the creation of new states out of this territory. Because it applied a portion of funds

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AMERICAN PLACES

Cumberland Gap, Appalachian Mountains

Many Americans who moved west to settle in the Northwest Territory traveled through the Cumberland Gap. It was the only place where settlers could reasonably cross the Appalachian Mountains from Virginia into Kentucky. As the map to the left shows, the Cumberland Gap is located where the states of Virginia, Kentucky, and Tennessee meet.

from the sale of lands toward building schools, it established the first system of public education and reinforced the Founders' belief that the success of a republican government relies on an educated people. The ordinance prohibited slavery in the Northwest Territory. It guaranteed the rights of the people who settled there and stated that "the utmost good faith shall always be observed" toward Native Americans. The ordinances of 1785 and 1787 created a plan for westward expansion. They also caused some unforeseen problems for the new nation. One of these problems would be growing conflict with Native Americans in the Northwest Territory.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What problems did territorial expansion create for the new nation?
2. **DETERMINE CHRONOLOGY** How did the Articles of Confederation and each of the land ordinances build on one another to pave the way for settlement?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Based on what you see on the map, what major waterways were newly available to settlers in the Northwest Territory?

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